PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY • PAPER 2 OPTION 26/27

Superpower Relations and the Cold War

1941–1991 • Origins of the Cold War • Cold War Crises • The End of the Cold War



Archival Primary Record: Soviet T-54/55 and US M48 Patton tanks face off at point-blank range across the border at Checkpoint Charlie, Friedrichstraße, Berlin, 27–28 October 1961.

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW • THE POST-WAR BALANCE OF TERROR 1941 – 1991

In the smouldering ruins of post-war Europe, two continental superpowers—the capitalist United States and the communist Soviet Union—embarked upon a titanic struggle for the ideological mastery of the globe. From the division of Germany and the heroic aerial lifeline of the Berlin Airlift to the nuclear brinkmanship of the Cuban Missile Crisis and the bloody proxy wars in Korea and Vietnam, the Cold War redefined warfare, diplomacy, and human survival. Confront how espionage, the balance of nuclear terror, the construction and dramatic collapse of the Berlin Wall, and the reformist gamble of Mikhail Gorbachev finally brought four decades of global confrontation to a peaceful conclusion without a direct third world war.

THE CANONICAL ENQUIRIES • SCHEME OF LEARNING DIRECTORY **A3 SADDLE-STITCH FORMAT**

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CORE CONCEPTS Ideology • Capitalism • Communism • Yalta & Potsdam • Iron Curtain • Truman Doctrine • Marshall Plan • Berlin Blockade • NATO • Cuban Missile Crisis • Proxy Wars • Fall of Berlin Wall

Chronological Turning Points & Causal Trajectory

Fourteen Pivotal Crises, Treaties & Structural Flashpoints (1945–1991)

4–11 Feb 1945

Yalta Summit & The Division of Germany

The "Big Three" agree to partition Germany and Berlin into four occupation zones and commit to free elections across liberated Eastern Europe.

16 July – 2 Aug 1945

Trinity Test & The Potsdam Conference

Truman reveals atomic capability to Stalin; deep rifts emerge over Soviet reparations, Polish borders, and the ideological control of Eastern Europe.

6 & 9 Aug 1945

Atomic Bombing of Hiroshima & Nagasaki

The United States establishes a temporary nuclear monopoly, intensifying Stalin's security paranoia and initiating four decades of nuclear arms race.

5 Mar 1946

Churchill's "Iron Curtain" Speech at Fulton

Winston Churchill warns that an iron curtain has descended from Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic, dividing Europe into hostile camps.

12 Mar 1947

The Truman Doctrine & Containment Doctrine

President Truman pledges $400 million in emergency aid to Greece and Turkey, establishing the foundational US policy of global communist containment.

3 Apr 1948

The Marshall Plan Enacted (European Recovery)

The US commits $13.3 billion to rebuild war-torn European economies, immunizing democracies against communism; Stalin forbids satellites to participate.

24 June 1948

Berlin Blockade & Allied Airlift Launched

Stalin severs all land and canal transit to West Berlin; Western Allies respond with Operation Plainfare, flying in 2.3 million tons of supplies.

4 Apr 1949

Creation of NATO & The Dual German States

Twelve Western nations sign the North Atlantic Treaty for collective defence. In May, West Germany becomes the FRG; in October, East Germany becomes the GDR.

25 June 1950

Outbreak of the Korean War Across 38th Parallel

North Korea invades the South; the UN authorizes military intervention under Douglas MacArthur, triggering Chinese intervention and trench stalemate.

14 May 1955

Warsaw Pact Established by the Soviet Union

In response to a rearmed West Germany joining NATO, the USSR and seven Eastern bloc satellite nations establish a unified military alliance.

13 Aug 1961

Construction of the Berlin Wall Begins

East German soldiers erect concrete barriers and barbed wire to halt the catastrophic flight of 2.7 million skilled citizens escaping to West Berlin.

16–28 Oct 1962

Cuban Missile Crisis & The Thirteen Days

US spy planes photograph Soviet nuclear missile sites in Cuba. Kennedy imposes a naval quarantine; secret negotiations avert nuclear holocaust.

9 Nov 1989

Fall of the Berlin Wall & Border Opening

Jubilant crowds dismantle border fortifications following botched travel decrees, precipitating the collapse of communist regimes across Eastern Europe.

25–26 Dec 1991

Gorbachev Resigns & Dissolution of the USSR

Mikhail Gorbachev resigns as Soviet President and the Soviet flag is lowered over the Kremlin, terminating the USSR and ending the Cold War.

The Geography of Superpower Confrontation & Proxy Conflict

Divided Europe, Nuclear Thresholds & Four Geopolitical Flashpoints (1945–1991)

THEATER I: THE DIVIDED EUROPEAN CONTINENT

Iron Curtain & German Partition

Following the defeat of the Third Reich, Europe was cleaved by a 4,300-mile military divide stretching from the Baltic to the Adriatic. Germany was partitioned in 1949 into the Western capitalist **Federal Republic of Germany (FRG)** and the Eastern Soviet-satellite **German Democratic Republic (GDR)**. West Berlin remained an isolated Western island 110 miles behind Soviet lines. Across this frontier, **NATO (1949)** and the **Warsaw Pact (1955)** deployed over three million troops and tactical nuclear warheads.

THEATER II: THE GLOBAL PROXY ARC

Caribbean, East Asia & Nuclear Perimeter

Deterred from direct nuclear war in Europe, superpower confrontation metastasized across the Global South. In East Asia, the 1949 victory of Mao Zedong's Chinese Communist Party shifted the balance of power, sparking vicious proxy conflicts along the **38th Parallel in Korea (1950–53)** and the **17th Parallel in Vietnam (1954–75)**. In the Caribbean, the 1959 Cuban Revolution breached the Monroe Doctrine, bringing Soviet ballistic missiles within **90 miles of the Florida coast**.

SUPERPOWER NUCLEAR ARSENALS (1945–1991) COMPARATIVE WARHEAD STOCKPILES

YEAR / LANDMARK	USA	USSR	STRATEGIC POSTURE
1945 (Hiroshima / Nagasaki)	2	0	**US Monopoly**
1949 (Soviet RDS-1 Test)	170	1	**Atomic Parity Quest**
1962 (Cuban Missile Crisis)	25,540	3,356	**8:1 US Superiority**
1975 (Détente / SALT I Accords)	27,500	19,000	**Parity & MAD**
1986 (Peak Global Stockpiles)	23,317	40,159	**Overkill Capacity**
1991 (START I / Soviet Dissolution)	19,008	35,000	**Treaty Drawdown**

STRATEGIC ALLIANCES & TREATIES COLLECTIVE SECURITY SYSTEMS

PACT / TREATY	FORMED	HEADQUARTERS	CORE STRATEGIC MANDATE
NATO	1949	Brussels, Belgium	Article 5 collective defence against Soviet invasion.
Warsaw Pact	1955	Moscow, USSR	Soviet-dominated military pact across 7 satellites.
SEATO	1954	Bangkok, Thailand	Containment pact blocking Asian communist advance.
Non-Aligned (NAM)	1961	Belgrade, YUG	120 nations rejecting superpower military blocs.
SALT I Accords	1972	Geneva / Moscow	First treaty capping ICBMs and ABM missile systems.
INF Treaty	1987	Washington D.C.	Elimination of all land-based medium-range missiles.

FLASHPOINT 01 • BERLIN SECTOR BOUNDARY

Checkpoint Charlie & Friedrichstraße (1961)

On 27–28 October 1961, American and Soviet tanks engaged in a 16-hour standoff with live rounds loaded at Checkpoint Charlie. Khrushchev's construction of the concrete Berlin Wall halted the flight of 2.7 million skilled East Germans to the West, cementing the physical division of Europe.

FLASHPOINT 02 • CARIBBEAN NUCLEAR PERIMETER

The Cuban Missile Quarantine (1962)

In October 1962, US U-2 spy planes discovered Soviet nuclear missile pads under construction at San Cristóbal, Cuba. Armed with warheads capable of striking Washington in twelve minutes, their deployment triggered Kennedy's naval quarantine, bringing the world within hours of thermonuclear war.

FLASHPOINT 03 • EAST ASIAN CONTAINMENT FRONTIER

The 38th Parallel DMZ & Korea (1950–1953)

When North Korean armour invaded the South in June 1950, President Truman committed US and UN forces under General MacArthur. MacArthur's counter-offensive to the Yalu River provoked 300,000 Chinese troops to enter the war, grinding into an armed trench stalemate across the 38th Parallel.

FLASHPOINT 04 • CENTRAL EUROPEAN TANK CORRIDOR

The Fulda Gap & NATO Tank Corridor

The Fulda Gap in Hesse, West Germany, was identified by NATO commanders as the most vulnerable armoured invasion route into Western Europe. Offering Soviet Eighth Guards Army tanks flat terrain to strike toward Frankfurt and the Rhine, NATO stationed elite armoured divisions and atomic artillery here.

ENQUIRY 01

Ideological Clash: Why could Capitalism and Communism never peacefully coexist?

CORE ENQUIRY Why could Capitalism and Communism never peacefully coexist?

[1.1] INCOMPATIBLE WORLDVIEWS: FREE MARKET CAPITALISM VS COMMAND SOCIALISM

What made Capitalist democracy and Marxist Communism fundamentally incompatible?

In the aftermath of the Second World War, the global balance of power was shattered. The great European empires of Britain, France, and Germany were bankrupt and devastated, leaving two continental titans standing supreme: the **United States of America** and the **Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR)**. Yet their temporary wartime marriage of convenience against Adolf Hitler concealed profound, irreconcilable ideological hostility. The United States championed **free-market capitalism**, an economic doctrine rooted in private enterprise, the profit motive, freedom of contract, and minimal state interference in commerce. For Americans, the right to acquire private property and trade freely was synonymous with human liberty itself. In stark contrast, the Soviet Union was organized upon **Marxist-Leninist socialism**: private property was outlawed, all banks, factories, and agricultural land were owned by the collective state, and production was directed by central state planners in Moscow to eliminate capitalist class exploitation.

[1.2] POLITICAL SYSTEMS: MULTI-PARTY DEMOCRACY VS BOLSHEVIK DICTATORSHIP

How did Allied intervention in the Russian Civil War create lasting Soviet paranoia?

This fundamental economic divergence was mirrored by totally opposing political philosophies. The United States was a **constitutional liberal democracy** founded upon universal suffrage, competing multi-party elections, a free press, religious liberty, and the rule of law guaranteed by an independent judiciary. American political culture viewed any concentration of absolute state authority as tyranny. Conversely, the USSR was a **totalitarian one-party dictatorship** governed exclusively by the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU). Vladimir Lenin and Joseph Stalin taught that bourgeois parliamentary democracy was a fraudulent facade designed by wealthy capitalists to deceive the working class. True working-class freedom required the "dictatorship of the proletariat", enforced by a ruthlessly disciplined vanguard party. All political opposition was banned, independent trade unions were crushed, media was subjected to total state censorship, and state terror was maintained by the secret police (the NKVD, later the KGB).

[1.3] HISTORICAL GRIEVANCES: 1917 INTERVENTION, APPEASEMENT & THE NAZI-SOVIET PACT

Why did Western appeasement drive Stalin into the cynical 1939 Nazi-Soviet Pact?

The mutual suspicion that poisoned superpower relations was not born in 1945, but was rooted in decades of historical betrayal. Following the **Bolshevik Revolution of 1917**, Western powers—including the United States, Britain, and France—dispatched expeditionary armies to Russia to fight alongside anti-communist "White" forces, attempting to strangle the fledgling Bolshevik regime in its cradle. Soviet leaders never forgot this foreign invasion. Throughout the 1930s, Stalin remained deeply convinced that Western capitalist powers were deliberately encouraging Nazi Germany to expand eastward to destroy the USSR, a suspicion seemingly confirmed by Britain and France appeasing Hitler at Munich in 1938. In turn, Western democracies were horrified in August 1939 when Stalin signed the cynical **Nazi-Soviet Pact** with Hitler, partitioning Poland and supplying the German war machine with grain and oil while London fought alone against the Luftwaffe.

[1.4] THE NUCLEAR MONOPOLY & THE EMERGING BALANCE OF TERROR

Why was the wartime Grand Alliance merely a marriage of pragmatic convenience?

The technological climax of the Second World War fundamentally transformed the stakes of this ideological rivalry. On 16 July 1945, American scientists successfully detonated the world's first atomic weapon in the New Mexico desert. When President Harry S. Truman deployed two atomic bombs against Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August 1945, killing over 150,000 people and forcing Japan's surrender, the United States established a temporary **nuclear monopoly**. Stalin interpreted Truman's possession of the atomic bomb not merely as a weapon to end the Pacific War, but as an explicit instrument of atomic blackmail designed to intimidate Moscow and roll back Soviet influence in Europe. Stalin immediately ordered Soviet physicists to work day and night to develop an atomic bomb, triggering a four-decade **nuclear arms race** where both nations stockpiled thousands of thermonuclear warheads capable of extinguishing human civilization.

[1.5] THE HISTORICAL VERDICT: GEOPOLITICAL VACUUM IN A RUINED EUROPE

How did the atomic bombing of Hiroshima transform the global balance of power?

By the end of 1945, the historic European states system that had governed world affairs since the Renaissance was dead. In its place stood an artificial, polarized continent divided between two military leviathans whose forces met along the River Elbe in Germany. The Cold War was not caused by a simple diplomatic misunderstanding or personal animosity between leaders; it was an existential, systemic confrontation between two universalist, messianic ideologies that each believed the other was historically doomed. As the French philosopher Raymond Aron famously observed, the post-war world was defined by a terrifying new geopolitical reality: "*Peace is impossible; war is improbable.*" Across this fractured landscape, the superpowers embarked on an unprecedented ideological war for the future of humanity.

ENQUIRY 02

Yalta to Potsdam (1945): How did wartime allies become bitter rivals?

CORE ENQUIRY How did wartime allies transform into bitter geopolitical rivals?

[2.1] THE YALTA SUMMIT (FEBRUARY 1945): THE BIG THREE'S FRAGILE CONSENSUS

What crucial compromises were reached at the Yalta Summit in Crimea?

In February 1945, with Nazi Germany collapsing under simultaneous Allied offensives, the "Big Three" leaders—US President **Franklin D. Roosevelt**, British Prime Minister **Winston Churchill**, and Soviet Premier **Joseph Stalin**—convened at the Crimean resort of Yalta. Meeting in the Livadia Palace, the leaders sought to design the architecture of the post-war world. On the surface, the conference was a triumph of pragmatic wartime diplomacy. The Big Three agreed that defeated Germany would be unconditionally disarmed, demilitarized, and partitioned into **four occupation zones** administered by Britain, the US, the USSR, and France. Berlin, although situated 100 miles deep within the Soviet occupation zone, would likewise be divided into four administrative sectors governed by an Allied Control Council.

[2.2] THE POLISH QUESTION & THE DECLARATION ON LIBERATED EUROPE

Why did the political fate of Poland shatter Allied consensus after Yalta?

Beneath this cordial surface lay deep, irreconcilable disagreements over the fate of Eastern Europe, particularly Poland. Britain had declared war in September 1939 to protect Polish sovereignty; Churchill insisted that Poland must regain genuine independence. However, the Soviet Union had lost over 27 million citizens repelling Hitler's invasion; Stalin was fanatically determined that Poland must never again serve as a geographic corridor for German invasion. Stalin demanded that the Soviet-Polish border be shifted westward to the Curzon Line, compensating Poland with German territory along the Oder-Neisse rivers. To preserve allied unity, Roosevelt brokered a vague compromise: Stalin signed the **Declaration on Liberated Europe**, pledging to permit "free and unfettered elections" across all liberated territories. In private, Stalin had no intention of allowing hostile anti-communist governments on Russia's borders.

[2.3] CHANGING OF THE GUARD: TRUMAN, ATTLEE, AND STALIN AT POTSDAM (JULY 1945)

How did the arrival of Harry Truman transform American policy toward Moscow?

When the Allied leaders reconvened at Potsdam outside ruined Berlin in July 1945, the international political landscape had transformed completely. Franklin D. Roosevelt had died suddenly of a cerebral hemorrhage in April, replaced by Vice President **Harry S. Truman**—a blunt, pugnacious Midwesterner who viewed Soviet behavior through a lens of profound moral suspicion. Midway through the conference, Winston Churchill was voted out of office in a British general election, replaced by Labour Prime Minister **Clement Attlee**. Stalin alone remained from the original wartime triumvirate. By July 1945, the common enemy that had bound the Grand Alliance together—Nazi Germany—was utterly destroyed. Without Hitler as a uniting threat, the ideological chasm between East and West opened with explosive force.

[2.4] THE TRINITY TEST & TRUMAN'S ATOMIC DIPLOMATIC LEVERAGE

How did the Trinity atomic test impact negotiations on the eve of Potsdam?

On the eve of the Potsdam conference, on 16 July 1945, Truman received a coded telegram confirming the successful detonation of the Trinity nuclear test in New Mexico. Armed with the knowledge that the United States now possessed the atomic bomb, Truman's diplomatic posture hardened dramatically. He resolved to abandon Roosevelt's conciliatory approach and adopt an "iron fist" towards Soviet demands. During a break in negotiations on 24 July, Truman casually approached Stalin and remarked that the United States possessed "a new weapon of unusual destructive force." Stalin nodded politely, urging Truman to make "good use of it against the Japanese." In reality, Soviet espionage agents in the Manhattan Project had kept Moscow fully informed of American nuclear progress; Stalin immediately dispatched urgent orders to speed up the Soviet bomb project.

[2.5] REPARATIONS AND THE DIVISION OF GERMANY: THE GRAND ALLIANCE DIES

Why did the Potsdam Conference conclude with bitter deadlock over reparations?

The primary point of contention at Potsdam was post-war German reparations. Having suffered catastrophic industrial devastation, Stalin demanded $20 billion in German reparations, with $10 billion delivered directly to the USSR from the western industrial zones. Truman and British Foreign Secretary Ernest Bevin fiercely refused, recalling how excessive reparations had crippled the Weimar Republic after 1919 and paved the way for Hitler. A fragile compromise was struck: each occupying power would extract reparations primarily from its own occupation zone, with the Soviets receiving an additional percentage of industrial machinery from the western zones in exchange for food shipments. In reality, this agreement laid the groundwork for the permanent economic and political partition of Germany. The Grand Alliance was dead, replaced by suspicion, fear, and hostile confrontation.

ENQUIRY 03 THE COLD WAR • 1945–1991

The Iron Curtain & The Berlin Blockade (1948–1949): The first flashpoint.

CORE ENQUIRY How did the Berlin Blockade permanently partition the European continent?

[3.1] CHURCHILL'S FULTON SPEECH: THE DESCENT OF THE IRON CURTAIN (1946)

Why was Winston Churchill's Fulton address a defining moment of the early Cold War?

Between 1945 and 1947, the Red Army established a stranglehold across Eastern Europe. Using what Hungarian communist Mátyás Rákosi termed **"salami tactics"**—slicing away non-communist political parties piece by piece through rigged elections, intimidation, and secret police murder—Stalin installed obedient puppet regimes in Poland, Romania, Bulgaria, Hungary, and Albania. In March 1946, Winston Churchill traveled to Westminster College in Fulton, Missouri, to deliver his seminal "Sinews of Peace" address with President Truman seated beside him. Churchill warned the world in stark, unforgettable terms: *"From Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic, an iron curtain has descended across the Continent."* Behind this line, ancient capitals were subjected to Soviet control, crushing democratic liberties. Stalin furiously denounced Churchill in the Soviet press, branding him a warmonger comparable to Adolf Hitler.

[3.2] THE TRUMAN DOCTRINE & MARSHALL PLAN: THE STRATEGY OF CONTAINMENT (1947)

How did the Truman Doctrine and Marshall Plan institutionalise containment?

In early 1947, Britain informed Washington that it was bankrupt and could no longer provide military aid to royalist forces fighting communist guerrillas in the Greek Civil War, or protect Turkey from Soviet naval demands. On 12 March 1947, President Truman addressed a joint session of Congress to announce a revolutionary departure in American foreign policy: the **Truman Doctrine**. Truman pledged that the United States would provide financial and military aid to "free peoples who are resisting attempted subjugation by armed minorities or by outside pressures." To back this commitment with economic muscle, Secretary of State George Marshall announced the **Marshall Plan** in June 1947, offering over $13 billion in economic aid to rebuild shattered European economies. Truman recognized that poverty and social desperation were the breeding grounds of communism; American economic aid eliminated that threat across Western Europe.

[3.3] SOVIET SALAMI TACTICS & COMINFORM: CONSOLIDATING EASTERN EUROPE

How did Soviet "Salami Tactics" and Cominform enforce communist control in the East?

Stalin interpreted the Marshall Plan as an act of American economic imperialism, designed to create an anti-Soviet military coalition and undermine Soviet influence. Moscow banned all Eastern European satellite nations, including Poland and Czechoslovakia, from accepting a single dollar of Marshall aid. In September 1947, Stalin established the **Cominform** (Communist Information Bureau) to coordinate communist parties across Europe and enforce rigid ideological obedience to Moscow. Any lingering hopes for Eastern European democracy were violently extinguished in February 1948 during the **Prague Coup**, when Czech communists seized complete power, and pro-Western Foreign Minister Jan Masaryk fell to his death from a government window. Europe was now completely polarized into two hostile economic and ideological blocs.

[3.4] THE BERLIN BLOCKADE & OPERATION VITTLES: THE 11-MONTH AIRLIFT (1948–49)

Why did Stalin impose the Berlin Blockade, and how did Operation Vittles defeat it?

The first catastrophic military showdown of the Cold War erupted over the divided city of Berlin. Frustrated by Soviet obstructionism, the Western Allies merged their occupation zones in 1948 to create a unified economic entity (Trizonia) and introduced a stable new currency, the **Deutsche Mark**, to revive economic growth. Furious that the Western currency was undermining the East German economy, Stalin resolved to force the Allies out of Berlin. On 24 June 1948, Soviet forces severed all road, rail, and canal routes connecting West Germany to West Berlin, cutting off electricity, food, and fuel to 2.5 million civilians. Instead of surrendering or invading by land, Truman launched the **Berlin Airlift** (Operation Vittles). For 324 days, American and British transport planes flew through narrow air corridors around the clock, landing a plane every 90 seconds at Tempelhof and Gatow airports. Delivering over 2.3 million tons of food, medicine, and coal, the airlift defeated Stalin's siege without firing a shot.

[3.5] THE PERMANENT DIVISION: FRG, GDR, NATO (1949) AND WARSAW PACT (1955)

How did the crisis permanently cement the military division of Europe into hostile blocs?

On 12 May 1949, humiliated by the success of the airlift and hurt by Western trade counter-blockades, Stalin backed down and reopened the transit corridors. However, the crisis had permanently militarized the Cold War. In May 1949, the western zones formally unified to create the democratic **Federal Republic of Germany (FRG / West Germany)**, with its capital at Bonn; in October, the Soviets established the communist **German Democratic Republic (GDR / East Germany)**. In April 1949, twelve Western nations signed the North Atlantic Treaty, creating **NATO**: a military alliance based on collective security (Article 5: an attack on one was an attack on all). When West Germany was allowed to rearm and join NATO in May 1955, the Soviet Union responded by establishing the **Warsaw Pact** with its seven Eastern European satellite states. The division of Europe was now cast in iron and stone.

ENQUIRY 04

Nuclear Brinkmanship: The Cuban Missile Crisis (1962).

CORE ENQUIRY How close did the superpowers come to thermonuclear annihilation in October 1962?

[4.1] THE CUBAN REVOLUTION: CASTRO, NATIONALIZATION, AND SOVIET ALLIANCE (1959)

How did Castro's revolution and the Bay of Pigs turn Cuba into a Cold War tinderbox?

In January 1959, young revolutionary guerrilla leader **Fidel Castro** overthrew the corrupt, US-backed military dictatorship of Fulgencio Batista in Cuba, just ninety miles south of Key West, Florida. When Castro nationalized American-owned sugar plantations, oil refineries, and telephone monopolies, the Eisenhower administration responded with economic sanctions, refusing to buy Cuban sugar. Facing economic collapse, Castro turned to the Soviet Union for commercial and military protection. Premier **Nikita Khrushchev** eagerly welcomed an ideological ally directly in the Western hemisphere, purchasing Cuban sugar and supplying Havana with crude oil and military equipment. In April 1961, newly inaugurated President **John F. Kennedy** authorized the catastrophic **Bay of Pigs invasion**: a CIA-orchestrated paramilitary assault by 1,400 Cuban exiles that was decisively crushed by Castro's forces within 72 hours, humiliating Kennedy and pushing Cuba entirely into Moscow's orbit.

[4.2] THE DISCOVERY: U-2 SPY PLANES & OPERATION ANADYR (OCTOBER 1962)

What did Major Heyser's U-2 spy plane discover in the jungle of San Cristóbal?

In the summer of 1962, Khrushchev initiated a clandestine gamble codenamed **Operation Anadyr**: the secret shipment of over 40,000 Soviet troops and dozens of medium- and intermediate-range nuclear ballistic missiles (MRBMs and IRBMs) to Cuba. Khrushchev had two strategic motivations: first, to deter another American invasion of Cuba; and second, to rectify the acute strategic nuclear imbalance. The United States possessed a massive 17-to-1 superiority in deliverable nuclear warheads, including nuclear-armed Jupiter missiles stationed directly on the Soviet border in Turkey. Stationing missiles in Cuba would double Soviet first-strike capability and place Washington, D.C., and major US cities within a terrifying three-minute warning window. On 14 October 1962, a high-altitude US Air Force **U-2 reconnaissance plane** piloted by Major Richard Heyser photographed Soviet nuclear missile launch pads under construction in San Cristóbal.

[4.3] THIRTEEN DAYS ON THE BRINK: EXCOMM, QUARANTINE & DEFCON 2

Why did Kennedy choose a naval quarantine over immediate surgical airstrikes?

On the morning of 16 October, President Kennedy was shown the reconnaissance photographs, initiating thirteen of the most terrifying days in human history. Kennedy convened an emergency council of twelve top national security advisors known as **ExComm** (Executive Committee of the National Security Council). Military hardliners, led by Air Force Chief of Staff General Curtis LeMay, aggressively demanded immediate "surgical" airstrikes to obliterate the missile sites, followed by a full-scale US military invasion. Kennedy resisted, recognizing that airstrikes risked killing Soviet military personnel and triggering a Soviet counter-attack against West Berlin, escalating into all-out thermonuclear war. Instead, Kennedy chose a middle course: a naval blockade, diplomatically termed a **"quarantine"** to avoid an official declaration of war. On 22 October, Kennedy addressed the nation on live television, revealing the missile sites and placing the US military on DEFCON 2—the highest alert level short of war.

[4.4] SECRET DIPLOMACY: TURKEY, QUARANTINE & KHRUSHCHEV'S TELEGRAMS

Why was "Black Saturday" the most dangerous single day in human history?

For five tense days, Soviet cargo ships carrying nuclear warheads steamed directly toward the American quarantine line while US warships waited with loaded guns. On 24 October, Soviet ships suddenly halted and turned back, leading Secretary of State Dean Rusk to famously whisper: *"We're eyeball to eyeball, and I think the other fellow just blinked."* Yet the danger remained acute. On 27 October ("Black Saturday"), an American U-2 plane was shot down over Cuba by a Soviet anti-aircraft missile crew acting without Moscow's orders, killing the pilot, Major Rudolf Anderson. Simultaneously, a Soviet submarine (B-59) depth-charged by US destroyers nearly launched a nuclear torpedo, prevented only by the courageous refusal of officer **Vasili Arkhipov**. Desperate to avoid catastrophe, Attorney General Robert F. Kennedy met secretly with Soviet Ambassador Anatoly Dobrynin, hammering out a compromise.

[4.5] DE-ESCALATION AND DETERRENCE: THE HOTLINE & PARTIAL TEST BAN TREATY

What secret compromises resolved the crisis, and what were the long-term results?

On 28 October 1962, Khrushchev announced over Radio Moscow that the Soviet Union would dismantle and return all nuclear missiles in Cuba under United Nations inspection. In exchange, Kennedy publicly pledged that the United States would respect Cuban sovereignty and never invade the island. Privately, Kennedy agreed to withdraw American Jupiter nuclear missiles from Turkey within six months. Having peered directly into the abyss of mutual annihilation, both superpowers recognized the urgent necessity of institutional de-escalation. In 1963, a direct **"hotline" teletype link** was established between the White House and the Kremlin to enable rapid communication during future crises. In August 1963, the US, USSR, and Britain signed the **Partial Nuclear Test Ban Treaty**, prohibiting nuclear tests in the atmosphere, outer space, and underwater. The era of unchecked brinkmanship gave way to fragile deterrence.

ENQUIRY 05 THE COLD WAR • 1945–1991

Proxy Wars: Why did the superpowers fight in Asia (Korea & Vietnam)?

CORE ENQUIRY Why did superpower confrontation metastasize into brutal proxy wars in Asia?

[5.1] COLD WAR GLOBALISATION: THE ASIAN DOMINO THEORY & NSC-68

How did the communist victory in China transform American Cold War strategy?

Between 1945 and 1949, the Cold War was primarily an ideological and political conflict concentrated in Europe. However, two seismic shocks in late 1949 permanently globalized the struggle: in August, the Soviet Union successfully tested its first atomic bomb (RDS-1); and in October, **Mao Zedong**'s Chinese Communist Party defeated Chiang Kai-shek's nationalists, establishing the People's Republic of China. The "fall of China" sent shockwaves through Washington, sparking fears that communism was on an aggressive global march. The US National Security Council issued **NSC-68**, a top-secret policy paper advocating a massive quadrupling of American defense spending to combat Soviet expansionism anywhere in the world. US foreign policy became defined by the **Domino Theory**: the belief that if one Asian nation succumbed to communism, its neighbours would inevitably topple like a row of dominoes.

[5.2] THE KOREAN WAR (1950–53): 38TH PARALLEL, INCHON, AND CHINESE INTERVENTION

Why did the Korean War become a bloody military stalemate along the 38th Parallel?

The first blood-soaked test of this globalized containment policy occurred on the Korean peninsula, which had been partitioned along the **38th Parallel** in 1945. On 25 June 1950, with Stalin's diplomatic endorsement and Soviet military equipment, communist North Korea under **Kim Il-sung** launched a massive surprise invasion of capitalist South Korea, capturing Seoul within three days. Viewing the invasion as a coordinated Kremlin test of Western resolve, Truman secured a United Nations Security Council resolution to deploy military forces, commanded by General **Douglas MacArthur**. Following MacArthur's brilliant amphibious landing at Inchon in September 1950, UN and US forces pushed North Korean armies to the Chinese border at the Yalu River. However, Mao Zedong intervened, unleashing 300,000 Chinese "volunteers" who drove Allied forces south in brutal winter combat. By July 1953, the war ground to an armistice stalemate along the 38th Parallel, leaving over three million soldiers and civilians dead.

[5.3] THE INDOCHINA CRUCIBLE: FROM DIEN BIEN PHU TO THE GULF OF TONKIN

How did French colonial collapse lead to deep American military entanglement in Vietnam?

Even as combat subsided in Korea, a second Asian crisis erupted in French Indochina (Vietnam). Led by communist nationalist **Ho Chi Minh**, the Viet Minh waged an anti-colonial war against French colonial forces, culminating in the catastrophic French surrender at **Dien Bien Phu** in May 1954. The subsequent 1954 Geneva Accords partitioned Vietnam temporarily at the 17th parallel into a communist North and a Western-backed South under Ngo Dinh Diem, promising nationwide elections in 1956. Fearing Ho Chi Minh would win over 80% of the vote, the United States backed Diem's cancellation of elections. By the early 1960s, communist guerrillas known as the **Vietcong (National Liberation Front)** launched an insurgency to reunify Vietnam. Following the disputed 1964 Gulf of Tonkin incident, President Lyndon B. Johnson escalated the conflict, deploying over 536,000 American ground combat troops by 1968.

[5.4] ASYMMETRIC WARFARE: CU CHI TUNNELS VS AIR MOBILITY & CHEMICAL WEAPONS

Why did high-tech American firepower fail to defeat the Vietcong guerrilla army?

In the dense tropical jungles of Vietnam, the world's foremost industrial superpower collided with the realities of **asymmetric guerrilla warfare**. The Vietcong avoided conventional pitched battles where overwhelming American artillery and air power could annihilate them. Instead, they moved in small squads under cover of darkness, deployed lethal booby traps (such as excrement-smeared punji stake pits), and lived in sprawling subterranean tunnel networks, such as the 250km complex at **Cu Chi**. Weapons and regular North Vietnamese troops flowed uninterrupted down the 16,000km **Ho Chi Minh Trail** through neutral Laos and Cambodia. In response, General William Westmoreland waged a war of attrition using helicopter-borne "Search and Destroy" sweeps, dropping 400,000 tons of napalm and spraying 20 million gallons of toxic defoliants like **Agent Orange**, alienating the rural peasantry they sought to protect.

[5.5] THE LESSONS OF ASIA: THE LIMITS OF SUPERPOWER HEGEMONY

How did the 1968 Tet Offensive shatter American domestic support for the war?

The proxy wars in Korea and Vietnam exposed the stark limitations of superpower military might. Despite dropping more bombs on Southeast Asia than fell during the entirety of World War II, the United States could not conquer a dedicated population fighting an anti-colonial war of national liberation on their home soil. The psychological shock of the 1968 communist **Tet Offensive**, combined with rising American casualties (eventually totaling 58,220 dead) and massive domestic anti-war protests, shattered Washington's political will. Following the 1973 Paris Peace Accords and complete American withdrawal, North Vietnamese tanks rolled into Saigon on 30 April 1975, reunifying the nation under communist rule. Asia proved that in proxy conflicts, local nationalism, geography, and ideological dedication frequently triumphed over advanced technological firepower.

ENQUIRY 06

Fall of the Berlin Wall (1989) and the Collapse of the Soviet Union (1991).

CORE ENQUIRY What structural forces brought down the Berlin Wall and dissolved the Soviet Union?

[6.1] THE CONSTRUCTION OF THE BERLIN WALL (AUGUST 1961) & CHECKPOINT CHARLIE

Why did the East German regime erect the Berlin Wall, and what did it symbolise?

Throughout the 1950s, divided Berlin remained a bleeding wound in the heart of the communist bloc. While living standards and democratic liberties flourished in West Berlin, East Germany suffered chronic shortages and political repression. Between 1949 and 1961, over **2.7 million East Germans**—disproportionately young, skilled professionals, doctors, and engineers—fled to the West through the open border in Berlin. Desperate to halt this catastrophic economic and demographic hemorrhage, East German leader Walter Ulbricht secured Soviet permission to seal the frontier. In the early hours of Sunday, 13 August 1961, East German troops tore up paving stones and unrolled coils of barbed wire, beginning the construction of the concrete **Berlin Wall**. Stretching for 96 miles with watchtowers, tripwire machine guns, and a mined "death strip", the Wall turned West Berlin into an enclosed island and became the ultimate visual symbol of communist tyranny.

[6.2] SOVIET STAGNATION, AFGHAN QUAGMIRE & THE COST OF THE ARMS RACE

How did the Afghan War and Reagan's defense build-up bankrupt the Soviet economy?

By the late 1970s, the Soviet economic model was decaying from within. Under the eighteen-year rule of **Leonid Brezhnev**, the USSR suffered from chronic agricultural failure, pervasive bureaucratic corruption, and industrial stagnation. While Soviet citizens queued for hours to buy basic foodstuffs like bread, meat, and shoes, the Kremlin channeled over 25% of the nation's entire gross national product into the military establishment to maintain nuclear parity with the United States. This economic exhaustion was compounded exponentially in December 1979 when the Soviet Union invaded **Afghanistan** to prop up a failing communist regime, becoming trapped in a ten-year guerrilla war against US-backed Afghan mujahideen that cost 15,000 Soviet lives and earned the moniker "the Soviet Union's Vietnam". In the 1980s, President **Ronald Reagan** dramatically escalated defense spending, proposing the Strategic Defense Initiative ("Star Wars"), a space-based missile shield that the bankrupt Soviet economy could not match.

[6.3] GORBACHEV'S REVOLUTION: GLASNOST, PERESTROIKA & ABANDONING THE BREZHNEV DOCTRINE

Why did Mikhail Gorbachev introduce the revolutionary policies of Glasnost and Perestroika?

In March 1985, 54-year-old **Mikhail Gorbachev** became General Secretary of the Soviet Communist Party, recognizing that the USSR was facing systemic collapse unless it modernized. Gorbachev introduced two revolutionary reform policies: **Glasnost** (openness), which permitted free public debate, freedom of the press, and open historical examination of Stalinist crimes; and **Perestroika** (restructuring), which decentralized state planning and allowed limited private enterprise. Crucially, Gorbachev abandoned the aggressive **Brezhnev Doctrine**, which had mandated Soviet military intervention to preserve communist satellite regimes (as in Hungary in 1956 and Czechoslovakia in 1968). In what diplomats called the "Sinatra Doctrine" (allowing nations to do it "their way"), Gorbachev announced that the Red Army would no longer intervene to prop up unpopular dictators in Eastern Europe.

[6.4] 9 NOVEMBER 1989: THE BREACHING OF THE BERLIN WALL & VELVET REVOLUTIONS

How did popular protest and a bureaucratic blunder bring down the Berlin Wall?

Gorbachev's renunciation of military force unleashed an unstoppable tsunami of democratic revolution across Eastern Europe in 1989. In Poland, the independent trade union **Solidarity** led by Lech Wałęsa swept free elections; in Hungary, reformers dismantled the barbed-wire border with Austria, allowing thousands of East Germans to escape to the West. The climax arrived in Berlin. On the evening of 9 November 1989, East German government spokesman **Günter Schabowski** mistakenly announced at a live press conference that new travel regulations allowing citizens to cross into West Berlin took effect "immediately, without delay." Hundreds of thousands of euphoric East and West Berliners rushed the border checkpoints, overwhelming bewildered guards. Armed with sledgehammers, citizens clambered onto the Wall and began demolishing it in an ecstasy of freedom. Within months, communist rule vanished across the Eastern Bloc.

[6.5] THE AUGUST COUP & THE DISSOLUTION OF THE SOVIET UNION (25 DEC 1991)

Why did the collapse of the Eastern European buffer zone lead to the dissolution of the USSR?

The collapse of the satellite empire triggered existential tremors within the Soviet Union itself. Loosening totalitarian controls allowed long-suppressed nationalist independence movements to erupt across the fifteen Soviet republics, beginning in the Baltic states of Lithuania, Latvia, and Estonia. In August 1991, hardline communist and KGB officials staged a desperate military coup in Moscow, placing Gorbachev under house arrest. However, the coup was defeated by mass civilian resistance led by Russian President **Boris Yeltsin**, who climbed atop a tank outside the Russian parliament to rally the people. On 25 December 1991, recognizing that the union had dissolved into fifteen independent sovereign republics, Mikhail Gorbachev resigned. At 7:32 PM, the red hammer-and-sickle Soviet flag was lowered over the Kremlin for the final time, replaced by the tricolor of the Russian Federation. The Soviet Union was extinct; the Cold War was over.

ENQUIRY 07

Assessment: Was the Cold War ever truly 'cold'?

CORE ENQUIRY Was the Cold War ever truly "cold" for the millions caught in its crossfire?

[7.1] THE EUROCENTRIC MYTH: THE "LONG PEACE" IN EUROPE VS GLOBAL SLAUGHTER

Why is describing the Cold War as a period of "peace" an inherently Eurocentric myth?

For decades, Western diplomatic historians described the era between 1945 and 1991 as the "Cold War" or the "Long Peace"—a period of international stability where the balance of power and nuclear deterrence successfully prevented a catastrophic World War III between the superpowers. However, contemporary global historians, such as Odd Arne Westad in *The Global Cold War*, have fundamentally challenged this Eurocentric narrative. While European capitals were spared military devastation, the conflict was neither peaceful nor "cold". In reality, the Cold War was a lethal, ideologically total conflict that was systematically outsourced to the Global South—Asia, Africa, the Middle East, and Latin America—where it was fought with ferocious conventional violence, leaving societies devastated and millions dead.

[7.2] THE HUMAN COST OF PROXY WAR: 20 MILLION DEAD ACROSS FOUR CONTINENTS

What was the true human toll of superpower proxy conflicts across four continents?

When evaluated from a global perspective, the human cost of the Cold War was apocalyptic. Historians estimate that over **twenty million human beings lost their lives** in Cold War-related conflicts between 1945 and 1991. In Korea, three million people died in three years of industrial warfare; in Southeast Asia, over three million Vietnamese, Cambodians, and Laotians perished under carpet bombing, chemical defoliation, and ground sweeps. Across sub-Saharan Africa, in Angola, Mozambique, and Ethiopia, superpower funding and weapons turned local decolonization struggles into decades-long civil wars that claimed hundreds of thousands of lives. In Latin America, CIA-backed military juntas in Chile, Argentina, Guatemala, and Nicaragua unleashed ruthless "Dirty Wars", disappearing, torturing, and murdering tens of thousands of suspected leftists.

[7.3] THE INVISIBLE WAR: ESPIONAGE, COVERT ACTION & PSYCHOLOGICAL WARFARE

How did covert intelligence operations wage an invisible global war in the shadows?

Beyond battlefields, the Cold War was waged through an all-pervasive shadow war of espionage, covert subversion, and psychological manipulation. Intelligence agencies like the American **Central Intelligence Agency (CIA)** and the Soviet **KGB** operated worldwide networks of spies, double agents, and codebreakers. In 1953, the CIA orchestrated Operation Ajax, overthrowing the democratically elected Prime Minister of Iran, Mohammad Mossaddegh, after he nationalized British oil assets; in 1954, the CIA orchestrated a military coup in Guatemala to depose President Jacobo Árbenz. Across the Eastern Bloc, secret police networks like the East German **Stasi** maintained massive files on millions of citizens, deploying informants within families and workplaces to crush independent thought and enforce totalitarian conformity.

[7.4] TECHNOLOGICAL COMPETITION: THE SPACE RACE & THE ARMS ESCALATION

How did the Space Race and technological rivalry serve as peaceful substitutes for war?

The ideological rivalry between the superpowers was fought with equal ferocity in the realms of science, culture, and prestige. When the Soviet Union launched **Sputnik 1**, the first artificial satellite, in October 1957, and sent **Yuri Gagarin** into orbit as the first human in space in April 1961, American pride was profoundly shaken. President Kennedy responded by committing the nation to land an American on the moon before the decade was out, achieving the milestone with Apollo 11 in July 1969. Simultaneously, both nations spent trillions of dollars building nuclear arsenals capable of destroying the planet dozens of times over. By the 1980s, the superpowers possessed over 60,000 nuclear warheads, creating the psychological condition of Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD), where global survival rested on a terrifying balance of nuclear fear.

[7.5] THE SYNOPTIC VERDICT: AN ERA OF TOTAL WAR WITHOUT DIRECT ARMAGEDDON

What enduring geopolitical and military legacies did the Cold War leave behind for our world?

In answering whether the Cold War was truly "cold", historians conclude that the term is an incomplete and misleading description of a global tragedy. Direct military conflict between the US and the USSR was averted solely because nuclear weapons transformed conventional superpower war into collective suicide. Yet this avoidance of direct armageddon came at an appalling price: the superpowers projected their ideological battle into vulnerable post-colonial nations, treating developing peoples as disposable pawns in a global chess match. The Cold War was an era of total ideological confrontation—a war fought through proxy armies, proxy victims, covert terrorism, economic strangulation, and nuclear terror. While humanity survived the ultimate nuclear nightmare, the scars of this four-decade conflict continue to shape the political boundaries, conflicts, and fault lines of our modern world.

Scholarly Perspectives & The Architecture of Cold War History

How Historians Explain the Origins, Proxy Confrontations & Soviet Collapse

DEBATE 01 • THE ORTHODOX SCHOOL

Soviet Expansionism & Marxist-Leninist Dogma

Writing in the immediate post-war decades, orthodox historians such as **Arthur Schlesinger Jr.** and **Herbert Feis** argued that the Cold War was the direct consequence of Soviet aggression. Driven by Marxist-Leninist universalist ideology and Joseph Stalin's pathological paranoia, Moscow violated the Yalta Declaration on Liberated Europe, imposed brutal puppet regimes across Eastern Europe, and sought world communist domination, forcing the United States to reluctantly mobilize in defence of Western liberty.

DEBATE 02 • THE REVISIONIST SCHOOL

American Economic Imperialism & Atomic Diplomacy

Emerging during the Vietnam War era, revisionist scholars such as **William Appleman Williams** and **Gar Alperovitz** argued that American economic expansionism was the primary catalyst. Seeking global open-door markets for surplus industrial goods, Washington sought to construct a worldwide capitalist empire. Truman's deployment of atomic diplomacy against Japan and aggressive encirclement forced Moscow into legitimate, defensive countermeasures to protect its devastated borders.

DEBATE 03 • THE POST-REVISIONIST SCHOOL

Systemic Inevitability & Mutual Misperception

Synthesising rival perspectives, post-revisionist historians such as **John Lewis Gaddis** argued that neither superpower was solely responsible. The catastrophic collapse of the European balance of power created a dangerous geopolitical vacuum. Compounded by conflicting ideological worldviews, mutual misperceptions, domestic political pressures, and classic security dilemmas, the division of Europe became a tragic, structurally unavoidable confrontation.

DEBATE 04 • THE POST-SOVIET ARCHIVAL TURN

Ideological Conviction & The Tail Wags The Dog

Exploiting declassified Kremlin, Chinese, and East European archives since 1991, historians such as **Odd Arne Westad** and **Vladislav Zubok** demonstrated that Soviet leaders were genuinely motivated by ideological conviction, not cynical realpolitik. Crucially, recent scholarship shows that ambitious third-world proxy leaders (such as Fidel Castro, Kim Il-sung, and Ho Chi Minh) frequently manipulated their superpower patrons, dragging them into perilous crises.

KEY DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY & CONCEPTUAL ARCHITECTURE

THEORETICAL SCHEMA • 8 CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMS

Containment (Kennan 1946/47):
The foundational US strategic foreign policy formulated by diplomat George F. Kennan, aiming to check the geopolitical spread of Soviet communism through patient, vigilant, and long-term counter-force at key geographical points.

Truman Doctrine (1947):
The landmark foreign policy commitment announced by President Harry S. Truman pledging American financial, logistical, and military assistance to free democratic nations resisting subjugation by armed minorities or external communist pressure.

Marshall Plan (1948):
The $13.3 billion European Recovery Program engineered by Secretary of State George C. Marshall to rebuild shattered Western European capitalist economies, eliminating the widespread poverty and instability that fostered communist appeal.

Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD):
The strategic military doctrine positing that full-scale nuclear weapon use by two opposing superpowers would result in the complete annihilation of both attacker and defender, transforming nuclear weapons into absolute deterrents.

Proxy War:
Regional armed conflicts across the developing world (e.g. Korea, Vietnam, Angola) where opposing superpowers supported, financed, and armed belligerent local factions to project power and secure hegemony without direct nuclear exchange.

Brinkmanship:
The high-risk diplomatic strategy, championed by Secretary of State John Foster Dulles, of deliberately escalating international crises to the absolute precipice of nuclear confrontation to compel the adversary to capitulate or retreat.

Brezhnev Doctrine (1968):
Soviet foreign policy decree declaring that any internal or external threat to socialist rule in any Eastern bloc satellite state constituted a collective threat to all socialist nations, legitimizing armed Soviet military invasion.

Glasnost & Perestroika (1985–91):
Mikhail Gorbachev's radical reform initiatives of political "openness" (free expression, transparency) and economic "restructuring", designed to revitalize the Soviet system but which inadvertently accelerated its collapse.

BACK COVER • RETRIEVAL ENGINE • ZERO ANSWERS PRINTED

Master Knowledge Retrieval Quiz

Standard Recall Protocol: 35 core retrieval questions testing factual mastery across all seven enquiries. Use for low-stakes weekly partner testing, silent memory flash-checks, or end-of-unit revision retrieval. All facts are verified in textbook narrative sections **[1.1] to [7.5]**. (Answers verified in class; zero answers printed.)

Enquiry 1: Ideological Foundations

Page 4 • Ref [1.1]–[1.5]

1. What two opposing economic doctrines defined the Cold War superpower confrontation?
2. How did American liberal democracy contrast with the Soviet one-party dictatorship?
3. Which 1918–19 foreign military intervention created deep, lasting Bolshevik suspicion of the West?
4. In what month and year did the United States detonate atomic weapons over Hiroshima and Nagasaki?
5. Which French philosopher famously observed in 1947: "Peace is impossible; war is improbable"?

Enquiry 2: Yalta to Potsdam (1945)

Page 5 • Ref [2.1]–[2.5]

6. Which three Allied leaders constituted the original "Big Three" at the Yalta Summit in February 1945?
7. What agreement at Yalta promised democratic institutions and free elections across liberated Europe?
8. Which new American president replaced Franklin D. Roosevelt at the Potsdam Conference in July 1945?
9. What was the codename for the successful American atomic bomb detonation tested in New Mexico in July 1945?
10. Into how many separate military occupation zones were Germany and Berlin divided in 1945?

Enquiry 3: Iron Curtain & Blockade

Page 6 • Ref [3.1]–[3.5]

11. In what American town and year did Winston Churchill deliver his famous "Iron Curtain" address?
12. What landmark American foreign policy announced in March 1947 committed the US to global containment?
13. How much financial aid did the Marshall Plan transfer to Western European nations to rebuild their economies?
14. What logistical operation flew 2.3 million tons of supplies into West Berlin during the 11-month blockade?
15. What collective defence treaty organisation was established by Western powers in Washington in April 1949?

Enquiry 4: The Cuban Missile Crisis

Page 7 • Ref [4.1]–[4.5]

16. What revolutionary leader seized power in Cuba in January 1959 after overthrowing the Batista regime?
17. What type of high-altitude US reconnaissance aircraft first photographed Soviet missile sites in Cuba in October 1962?
18. What action did President Kennedy choose to take against Cuba on 22 October 1962 rather than an immediate invasion?
19. What highest peacetime military readiness alert did the US Strategic Air Command reach during the crisis?
20. What secret reciprocal concession did President Kennedy offer regarding US missiles in Turkey to secure a deal?

Enquiry 5: Proxy Wars in Asia

Page 8 • Ref [5.1]–[5.5]

21. Along what line of latitude was the Korean peninsula divided following the Second World War?
22. What daring amphibious landing did General Douglas MacArthur execute in September 1950?
23. Which foreign superpower launched an unexpected military counter-offensive in Korea in late 1950?
24. What 1954 military defeat ended French colonial rule in Indochina and divided Vietnam at the 17th Parallel?
25. What vast underground network did the National Liberation Front (Vietcong) use to survive American aerial bombardment?

Enquiry 6: Berlin Wall & Soviet Collapse

Page 9 • Ref [6.1]–[6.5]

26. In what month and year did the East German government begin constructing the Berlin Wall?
27. What were Mikhail Gorbachev's twin reform policies of "political openness" and "economic restructuring"?
28. What 1968 Soviet military doctrine was formally abandoned by Gorbachev, allowing satellite states self-determination?
29. On what exact date in November 1989 did East German border guards open checkpoints at the Berlin Wall?
30. On what exact date did Mikhail Gorbachev resign as president, formally dissolving the Soviet Union?

Enquiry 7: Synoptic Assessment

Page 10 • Ref [7.1]–[7.5]

31. Approximately how many people died in regional proxy conflicts across the Global South during the Cold War?
32. What 1975 international accords recognised European borders and established human rights commitments?
33. What military concept (MAD) ensured that a nuclear strike by either superpower would lead to mutual destruction?
34. What satellite launched by the USSR in October 1957 initiated the Cold War space and missile race?
35. How did historians define the paradox of European stability coexisting with catastrophic global proxy violence?